

# The Ash Map

Seven uses for hardwood ash that your grandmother knew and the modern world forgot

## HARDWOOD VS SOFTWOOD ASH

- Always use hardwood ash (oak, hickory, maple, beech). It contains significantly more potassium and calcium carbonate - the compounds that make ash useful.
- Softwood ash (pine, spruce, fir) has lower mineral content and more resinous residue. Avoid for lye-making and garden use.
- Store ash dry in a sealed metal or ceramic container. Wet ash loses potassium rapidly and can heat spontaneously. Never store in plastic.

## USE 1 - LYE-MAKING (POTASH)

- Lye (potassium hydroxide solution) was the foundation of traditional soap-making and a dozen other homestead processes.
- Process: pack ash into a wooden barrel or ceramic vessel with a hole at the bottom. Pour rainwater or soft water slowly over it. Collect the dark liquid that drips through - this is your lye.
- Test strength: a traditional egg float test - fresh egg should barely float, not sink. Strong enough lye = working lye for soap.
- Safety: lye is caustic. Wear gloves and eye protection. Never use aluminium vessels - it reacts violently.

## USE 2 - TRADITIONAL ASH SOAP

- Combine 1 litre of tested lye with 500ml of rendered animal fat (tallow or lard) or plant oil (coconut, olive).
- Heat slowly while stirring until it reaches 'trace' - mixture thickens like pudding. Pour into moulds.
- Cold-process ash soap needs 4-6 weeks to cure before use. Soft soap (not fully cured) can be used immediately for laundry.
- Ash soap is naturally antibacterial and genuinely cleans. The same soap your great-grandmother used.

## USE 3 - GARDEN APPLICATION

- Ash raises soil pH (alkalinity) and adds potassium and calcium - ideal for brassicas, root vegetables, and fruiting plants.
- Application rate: 1-2 cups per square metre, worked into the top 5cm of soil. Once per season, not more.
- Do NOT use near acid-loving plants (blueberries, azaleas, rhododendrons, potatoes) - it will damage them.
- Do NOT use on seedlings - it can burn young roots. Apply in autumn so it integrates by spring.

## USE 4 - SEED STORAGE PROTECTANT

- Mix a small amount of clean dry ash with dried seeds before storage. The ash absorbs moisture and deters insects.
- Ratio: roughly 1 part ash to 10 parts seeds by volume. Shake gently to coat.
- Works particularly well for bean and corn seeds. Traditional method used across Asia, Africa, and Latin America for centuries.

## USES 5-7: PEST BARRIER, DRAIN DEODORIZER, WOOD & LEATHER

- Slug & snail barrier: ring plants with dry ash. Reapply after rain. Works while ash remains dry.
- Natural drain deodorizer: pour 2 tablespoons of dry ash down a slow drain, follow with boiling water. Absorbs odour, mild abrasive action.
- Wood & leather preservation: rub fine ash into wooden tool handles or leather goods with a dry cloth to condition and protect against moisture.

#### WHAT NOT TO USE ASH FOR

- Never on aluminium surfaces - potash reacts with aluminium, causing pitting and corrosion.
- Never near acid-loving plants (blueberries, potatoes, strawberries) - it raises pH and damages them.
- Never wet ash stored in sealed containers - it can generate heat. Keep it dry or leave open until cooled.

**>> THE SAGE'S TIP: *The best ash comes from a clean fire with no accelerants, no treated wood, no painted wood. Hardwood only. The cleaner the fire, the more useful the ash.***

*Your wood stove produces medicine, fertiliser, and soap. Stop throwing it away. - The Sage*

